



(12) **United States Plant Patent**
Moon

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(54) **LAUREL OAK TREE NAMED ‘QHMTF’**

(50) Latin Name: *Quercus hemisphaerica*
Varietal Denomination: **QHMTF**

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patent is extended or adjusted under 35
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A01H 5/00 (2006.01)

(52) **U.S. Cl.**
USPC **Plt./225**

(58) **Field of Classification Search**
USPC Plt./225, 216
See application file for complete search history.

(56) **References Cited**

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(57) **ABSTRACT**

A Laurel oak tree (*Quercus hemisphaerica*) named
“QHMTF” having a compact habit with dense canopy,
vigorous growth rate, shiny rich dark green foliage in
summer, and semi-evergreen holding leaves until late spring
and also capable of being reproduced reliably from vegeta-
tive cuttings.

6 Drawing Sheets

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Latin name: *Quercus hemisphaerica*.
Varietal denomination: ‘QHMTF’.

BACKGROUND OF THE INVENTION

The present invention relates to a new and distinct variety
of Laurel Oak Tree (*Quercus hemisphaerica*), which I have
named “QHMTF”.

Discovery: I discovered my new tree in November of
2005 growing as a seedling in a production field in Logan-
ville, Walton County, Ga., among a group of cultivated
Laurel Oaks. These trees were grown from bare-root seed-
lings purchased of unknown *Quercus hemisphaerica* parents
purchased in the winter of 2000 from a nursery in Florida.
In the winter of 2003, these liners were relocated from my
liner field to a production field. It was here that I discovered
‘QHMTF’. Evaluation of this tree continues in this field in
Walton County, Loganville, Ga.

Propagation: ‘QHMTF’ was asexually propagated by the
method of vegetative cuttings at my direction in the summer
of 2008 in Walton County, Ga. This propagation from
softwood cuttings and resulting progeny has proven the
characteristics of my new variety to be genetically stable.
Furthermore, these observations have confirmed that my
new variety represents a new and improved variety of Laurel
Oak as particularly evidenced by the compact habit with
dense canopy, dominant central leader, fibrous root system,
vigorous growth rate, and shiny, rich, dark green foliage in
summer and holding onto leaves until spring along with the
fact that it is the only known *Quercus hemisphaerica* to be

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reproduced from softwood cuttings. These genetic traits can
be consistently reproduced by asexual propagation.

Uniqueness: ‘QHMTF’ was discovered in a block of
seedling Laurel Oak (unknown *Quercus hemisphaerica* par-
ents) purchased from a supplier of liners in Florida. I claim
that the genetic characteristics of this tree are the result of
naturally occurring cross-pollination. Due to the nature of
the seedling purchase, comparison of surrounding cross
pollinators is not possible. The characteristics of my new
tree along with the fact that it is the only known *Quercus*
hemisphaerica to be reproduced from softwood cuttings
distinguish it from other typical seedling Laurel Oak includ-
ing ‘Darlington’. At the time this tree was selected, I
observed ‘QHMTF’ Laurel Oak as a 2" caliper tree exhib-
iting a compact, dense canopy, dominant central leader, and
shiny, dark green foliage. The remainder of the trees in this
block had irregular structure and medium green foliage
color.

Use: ‘QHMTF’ was observed for a period of several years
and is believed to be particularly useful for street tree
planting and in large areas such as golf courses, commercial
sites and parks. ‘QHMTF’ will also benefit growers who will
profit from a fast growing tree with consistent form.

BRIEF SUMMARY OF THE INVENTION

Background: Laurel Oak is native to coastal plain and
piedmont areas from southern New Jersey to Florida to east
Texas and Southeast Arkansas. It thrives in the heat and
humidity of the Southeast and can be found in established

dune areas, scrub oak sandhills, stream banks and occasionally in mixed woods. Laurel Oak prefers moist, well-drained soils in these areas but adapt readily to harsh conditions. This species is typically pyramidal-rounded with ultimate height of 40 to 60 feet and spread of 30 to 40 feet. My new cultivar differs from the species in that it is asexually reproduced, has a compact habit with dense canopy, dominant central leader, fibrous root system, vigorous growth rate, and shiny, rich, dark green foliage in summer and holding onto leaves until spring. The ultimate height and width of 'QHMTF' is not known. I expect my new variety of Laurel Oak to perform as well as the species.

Industry Representation: Cultivated Laurel Oak is predominately represented in the industry by seedling material reproduced by acorn. This accounts for a high degree of variability in the industry, both in the landscape industry and nursery. Seedling Laurel Oak (including 'Darlington') is variable in growth rate and habit, typically does not have a central leader, has a sparse, shallow root system, and tends to be open in youth. At time of submission, I am not aware of any other commercially available cultivar Laurel Oak. 'QHMTF' has a compact habit with dense canopy, dominant central leader, fibrous root system, vigorous growth rate, shiny, rich, dark green foliage in summer and holding onto leaves until spring along; it is the only known *Quercus hemisphaerica* reproduced from softwood cuttings. These genetic traits can be consistently reproduced by asexual propagation which makes my selection uniquely different from seedling Laurel Oak (including 'Darlington') at time of submittal.

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

The accompanying photographs depict the color of the tree and foliage of my new variety as nearly as is reasonably possible to make the same in a color illustration of this character.

FIG. 1 is a photograph of the original parent 'QHMTF' variety from which the progeny are derived taken in the summer at seven years of age and four inch caliper at an observation area showing form and habit;

FIG. 2 is a field row photograph of the progeny in the fall at four years of age with each tree showing a dominant central leader and variations in fall color;

FIG. 3 is a photograph of the interior canopy of the progeny at four years of age showing a dominant central leader;

FIG. 4 is a photograph of the bark of the progeny taken at five inch caliper and seven years of age showing color and smoothness of my new variety;

FIG. 5 is a field row shot of progeny taken at 5 inch caliper and seven years of age with each tree showing a dominant central leader, and

FIG. 6 is a photograph of the shiny, dark green foliage of the progeny at seven years of age.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF THE INVENTION

Botanical Description of the Plant: The following is a detailed description of 'QHMTF' Laurel Oak with color terminology in accordance with The Royal Horticulture Society (R.H.S.) Colour Chart (2001) except where the context indicates a term having its ordinary dictionary meaning. My new tree has not been observed under all growing conditions, and variations may occur as a result of

different growing conditions. All progeny of my new variety, insofar as have been observed, have remained genetically stable in all characteristics described hereinafter. Other than as set out hereinafter, as of this time, no other characteristics have been observed which are different from common Laurel Oak trees, which have been observed by the inventor. Parentage: Naturally occurring cross-pollinated seedling of (unknown *Quercus hemisphaerica* parents) grown from bare-root liner purchased in the winter of 2001 from a nursery in Florida.

Locality where grown and observed: 'QHMTF' Laurel Oak trees are currently in production at in Walton County, Ga. This area of Walton County has a clay loam soil type with rainfall that varies between 30" and 60" annually. This particular area is located in USDA Hardiness Zone 7.

Size and growth rate: The original parent 'QHMTF' tree, aged 5 years measured 6.25" caliper at 12" above the ground. The height of 24' and spread of 13' provides a 1.85 height to width ratio. Average growth rate is between 1.00" to 1.25" per year.

Foliage: Typical of the species, alternate, simple, evergreen until spring, lanceolate, elliptic to oblanceolate, obovate, or oblong-obovate, 1.25" to 4" long, 1/2" to 1.25" wide, acute or obtuse, usually with a bristle-tip, cuneate or obtuse at base. The spring color emerges from a greyed-orange (RHS N170) to a yellow-green (RHS 144). Mature foliage is lustrous dark green above like (RHS 137A) and lighter green below like (RHS 137C). The fall color is a russet red like (RHS N167B). The petiole is 0.25" long, yellowish like (RHS 10B). The petiole diameter is 1/16". Buds: Imbricate, shiny greyed purple like (RHS 183D) 1/8" to 1/4" long, essentially glabrous, small for oak buds.

Flowers: Typical of species. Flowers are borne in clustered catkins in March and April, usually lasting for 10 to 14 days.

Fruit: Typical of the species being short-stalked (virtually sessile), the nut subglobose to ovoid about 1/2" in both diameter and length and brown in color like (RHS 200B) and enclosed 1/4" by the saucer-shaped cap which is grey-brown like (RHS 199B).

Trunk: Typical of the species. The bark is initially smooth, and brown like (RHS N200B), becoming darker with maturity.

Branching: Slightly ascending to nearly horizontal at the base, emerging at 80-90 degrees from the trunk. Upper branches are more ascending, emerging at 45 degrees or more from the trunk. Color is brown like (RHS 200B).

Shape: Compact, pyramidal with dense branching and dominant central leader.

Root system: Fibrous, typical of *Quercus hemisphaerica*.

Vigor: The initially discovered tree has averaged between 1.0" to 1.25" in caliper per year. The root development from time of softwood cuttings to a finished rooted 3 1/2" pot is five to seven weeks.

Disease: Free from disease.

Pests: Displays spider mite resistance but does show signs of mild leaf hopper damage.

What is claimed is:

1. A new and distinct variety of Laurel oak tree named "QHMTF" substantially as herein shown, illustrated and described, characterized particularly as to novelty by its compact habit with dense canopy, vigorous growth rate, shiny rich dark green foliage in summer, and semi-evergreen holding leaves until spring.

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